Author’s Note

I stepped down from the office of governor of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on 4 September 2013. In the months before I left the RBI and for long afterwards, several people have asked me if I planned to write a book on my time as governor. I remained dismissive of the suggestion if only because I found the idea of writing a book very daunting.

In mid-2014, I took up a position as a Distinguished Visiting Fellow at the National University of Singapore (NUS). I was employed primarily by the business school although my appointment was also partly supported by the Institute of South Asian Studies and the Monetary Authority of Singapore. The job involved giving occasional lectures on issues in central banking, the financial sector and the global economy. Many faculty and students who heard the lectures urged me to put those ideas, thoughts and experiences together in a book.

Encouraged by all this urging, I decided to bite the bullet and started on the book in earnest in mid-2015. This book is an account of my term as governor during 2008–13. This was, by all accounts, an unusually turbulent period for the world and for India. The global financial crisis erupted in full blast within a week of my stepping into the Reserve Bank. Just as India started recovering from the impact of the crisis, the action shifted to combating a decade-high, stubborn inflation during 2009–11 which segued into a battle against a sharp depreciation of the rupee from mid-2012 up until the close of my tenure in September 2013. At its heart, the book is about the dilemmas I confronted in leading the Reserve Bank through a period of extraordinary economic and political challenges.

This book is not an attempt to defend my decisions as governor, so much as to explain the circumstances in which I acted. It is not an effort to reshape the narrative of that period but to convey my perspectives on the issues and challenges which shaped that narrative in the first place.